

A large yellow circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing text in a dark gray serif font.

God decides to
bring about the
existence of
contingent things

The right hand side of the dilemma might not look too bad at first. We might think, for example, that we can explain God's creation of contingent things in terms of God's deciding to create contingent things.

But this just gives us a new fact:

And this fact must be necessary, or contingent.

If it is necessary, then, again, premise (1) of our initial argument is false.

And if it is contingent, then by the PSR it must have some explanation. But what could this be?



Leibniz's
argument



the
PSR



objections
to the
PSR

The problem for Leibniz's argument is that we can keep asking this question. And this seems to give us just two choices.

Option 1.

We eventually supply a necessary fact as an explanation of the fact that God creates contingent things. But that threatens to make the existence of contingent things necessary, which falsifies premise (1) of Leibniz's argument.

Option 2.

There is an infinite series of contingent facts, each one of which explains the next.

Option 2 might not look so bad. This series would seem to be like Leibniz's example of the geometry books, where each book in the series is explained by the preceding one.

It is hard to see how we can answer this question without either making the existence of the series (and hence the existence of contingent things) necessary or appealing to yet another contingent fact, which then (if the PSR is true) would need explanation.

But the problem is that the existence of the infinite series is itself contingent. So, as in the case of the geometry books, we can ask: what explains why there is such a series at all? And if the principle of sufficient reason is true, this question must have an answer.



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Good ideas to



containing thinning

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the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are employed in the public sector has increased by 1.5 million, from 2.5 million in 1980 to 4 million in 1999. The public sector has also become an important employer of women, with 5.5 million women employed in the public sector in 1999, compared with 4.5 million in 1980.

There are a number of reasons why the public sector has become an important employer of women. One reason is that the public sector has a high proportion of women in its workforce. In 1999, 88% of the public sector workforce were women, compared with 78% in 1980.

Another reason is that the public sector has a high proportion of women in its senior management. In 1999, 33% of the public sector senior management were women, compared with 23% in 1980. This is a significant increase, and it suggests that the public sector is becoming more gender equal in its senior management.

A third reason is that the public sector has a high proportion of women in its part-time workforce. In 1999, 44% of the public sector workforce were part-time, compared with 34% in 1980. This is a significant increase, and it suggests that the public sector is becoming more flexible in its employment arrangements.

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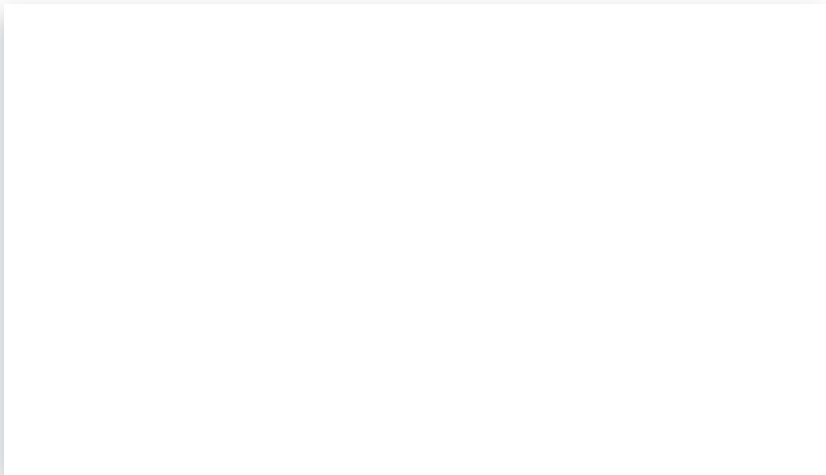
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explains why there is such a series at all? And if the principle of

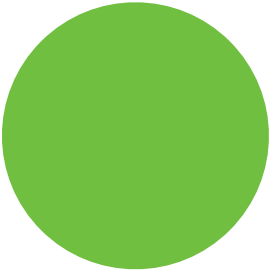
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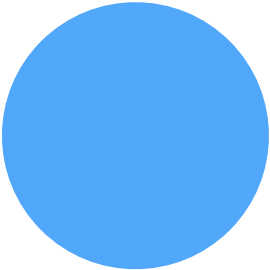
... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.









be Good.

cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could

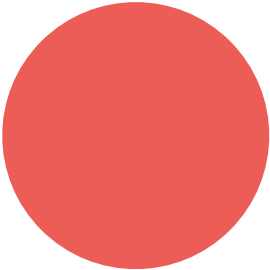
Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first

simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to

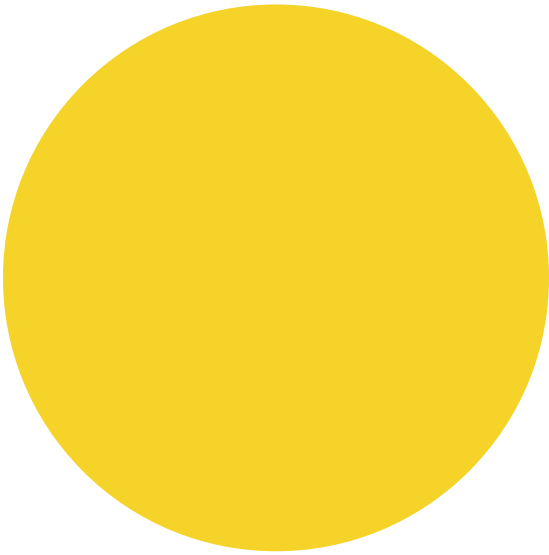




Leibniz's
argument















































































































If it is necessary, then, again, premise (1) of our initial argument is false.



could this be?

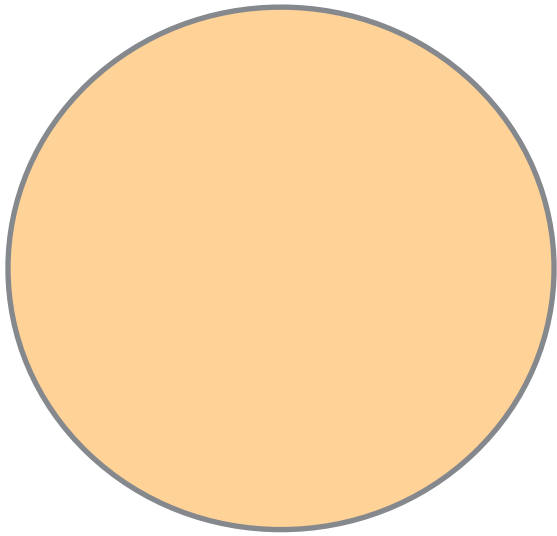
And if it is contingent, then the PSR must have some explanation. But what

[This is the end of the main lecture. What follows is another way to

lecture. I include it here for those interested in pursuing this issue

further $\rightarrow$ it is purely optional.]

present the dilemma for Leibniz's argument discussed at the end of







































































































And this fact must be necessary, or contingent.